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[00:13:41] The House will come to order. Members, please take your seats. Head page. The House is now in session. All persons not entitled to privileges of the floor, please retire to the gallery.

[00:13:56] The members will rise and be led in prayer by Reverend Kenan Thomas, lead pastor, Shiloh Baptist Church, Fredericksburg, and remain standing for the Pledge of Allegiance to the United States of America, which will be led by the delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Good afternoon. Let us pray.

[00:14:16] God Almighty, you have given us this day and daily bread to fulfill the responsibilities you have entrusted to us as civil servants and public leaders. On this day, for this House of Delegates session, we ask for your sound wisdom, which avoids extremity and seeks common ground.

[00:14:34] We ask for understanding minds, which grants us insights into lived realities beyond our own experience. And we ask for peaceable speech, which necessitates persuasion and not arrogance.

[00:14:51] Grant these elected officials these virtues today, tomorrow, and as long as they serve the Commonwealth of Virginia. Amen. Amen. Presidious to the flag of the United States of America, to the republic for which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible.

[00:15:19] The members will answer the roll call by indicating their presence on the electronic voting board.

[00:15:45] Clark will close the roll. Mr. Speaker, a quorum is present. Pursuant to House Rule 3, I've examined and approved the General House of Delegates for February 18, 2026. Motions of resolutions under Rule 39 pursuant to the provisions of Rule 40 are now in order. Does the clerk have any announcements or communication?

[00:16:01] Yes, communication from the Senate. The Senate has rejected the House amendments to the following legislation. Senate Bills 27, 74, 323, 337, 425, 581, and 589.

[00:16:17] Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House insist on its amendments and request a committee of conference on the previously reported legislation. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring moves that the House insist on the previously announced legislation as announced by the clerk. As many in favor, the motion will say aye.

[00:16:34] Aye. All those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to the House. There will be committee conference reports on the announced legislation by the clerk. Mr. Speaker, Members of the House, in this first portion of the morning, our pursuant to House Rule 40, Speaker, a request that you use your request to speak button for the agenda items listed for reference up on the voting board.

[00:16:53] The delegate from Fredericksburg, Delegate Cole. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Arise for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker, members of the House. It is my distinct honor to introduce our guest for today's invocation, the Reverend Kenan Thomas, who is seated in the back.

[00:17:09] A longtime resident of central New Jersey, Reverend Thomas testifies both in word and deed that God is a source of his strength and the strength of his life. A 2008 graduate of the real H.U., Howard University in Washington, D.C., he earned a Bachelor of Arts in Telecommunications Management before beginning a four-year career in media sales in New York City.

[00:17:31] Yet in May of 2011, he discerned a higher calling, the call to gospel ministry. Faithfully pursuing that calling, he earned his Master of Divinity degree from Drew Theological Seminary in 2015. The Reverend Thomas served at Shiloh Baptist Church in Plainfield, New Jersey under his father, Reverend Dr. Gerald Lamont Thomas, and at First Baptist Church in Lincoln Gardens, under the leadership of Dr. DeForest Cerise Jr., before joining Alfred Street Baptist Church in Alexandria, Virginia, where he worked until October 2022, before he accepted his call to serve as pastor of the Shiloh Baptist Church news site in Fredericksburg, Virginia. Outside of

[00:18:10] the pulpit, Reverend Thomas most enjoys engaging with what he calls God's most treasured creation people. And of all God's creation, his favorite people, person, is his beloved wife, First Lady Valerie Young. Mr. Speaker, members of the house, I hope it would be the warm pleasure of the body to give Reverend Thomas a warm house welcome. Welcome, Reverend Thomas, and thank you for the very timely prayer this morning. The delegate from Winchester, Delegate Wiley. Thank you,

[00:18:44] Mr. Speaker. I rise for a motion. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I'll make a Motion to move H.R. 130 found on page 12 to February 24th. Goodbye. Without objection, House Resolution 130 found on page 12 will go by until February 24th.

[00:19:04] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Rise for an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you. With us in the gallery this morning are members of the George Mason University's Jurisprudence Learning Community, if they could stand, please.

[00:19:21] Mr. Speaker, over the year-long program, students learn the history of the American legal system and explore how laws are made, interpreted, and enforced at the federal, state, and local levels. These students are here today to observe legislative session proceedings and learn more about how the General Assembly works, and they also study and dive deeply into Supreme Court decisions.

[00:19:44] I would hope that everybody give them a warm house welcome.

[00:19:56] Welcome, welcome to the Capitol today. The delegate from Giles County, Delegate Ballard. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Duncan has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker, members of the body. Today, we have students and staff from Macy McClarity Elementary Middle School visiting with us, and I ask that they please stand.

[00:20:14] Members of the House, Macy McClarity is located in my district and in my hometown of Parrisburg, Virginia, and has been serving our community since its founding in 1949. At Macy McClarity, their mission is to foster academic, emotional, social, and physical growth and all their students within a safe learning environment.

[00:20:34] They do this by developing positive relationships, respecting differences, encouraging creativity, and collaborating as a team to build a community of respectful, lifelong learners. Mr. Speaker, Mason McClarity currently serves 433 students in grades pre-K through seventh grade and offers a comprehensive curriculum, including core subjects such as math, science, reading, and social studies.

[00:20:58] and the school also offers enrichment programs in music, art, STEM, computer science, robotics, and physical education. Macy McClarity prides itself on being an integral part of our community in Perisburg. And with that, Mr. Speaker, I hope it is the pleasure of the House to give the students and staff from Macy McClarity a very warm House welcome.

[00:21:25] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. The Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Sullivan. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise with two motions and an introduction. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I move that House Joint Resolution 152, found on page 12 of today's calendar, be taken up out of order.

[00:21:44] Clerk will report a resolution. House Joint Resolution 152 now before you, commending the Pentagon Memorial Fund. Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Sullivan. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I move adoption of the resolution and request to speak to that motion. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I rise today to recognize a very distinguished group of people in our gallery.

[00:22:07] They are representatives from the Pentagon Memorial Fund, and I ask them to please rise. Mr. Speaker, nearly 25 years ago, our nation watched as our way of life and our very freedom came under attack.

[00:22:22] For those of us in the Commonwealth, that tragedy was not distant. It was felt with devastating proximity. At 9.37 a.m., 184 innocent lives were lost when American Airlines Flight 77 struck the Pentagon right here on Virginia soil.

[00:22:44] While that day showed us the worst of humanity, Mr. Speaker, it also revealed the very best of the American spirit. We saw it in the first responders who ran toward the smoke and the communities that rose up in resilience. From that grief, the families of the fallen have established the Pentagon Memorial Fund.

[00:23:05] Their mission is simple yet sacred, Mr. Speaker, to ensure that our nation honors the solemn promise to never forget. Mr. Speaker, many of us in this chamber remember exactly where we were on that terrible morning.

[00:23:21] But for a new generation of Americans, September 11th is a chapter in a history book rather than a lived memory. So as we approach the 25-year remembrance, the Memorial Fund is here to ensure that the stories of bravery and loss remain a permanent part of our Commonwealth's heart.

[00:23:39] Mr. Speaker, I hope that the House will extend a warm welcome to our guests from the Pentagon Memorial Fund. But first, Mr. Speaker, I move that when the House adjourned today, it do so in the honor and in memory of the victims of September 11, 2001.

[00:23:57] The delegate for Fairfax, Delegate Sullivan, moves the adoption of House Joint Resolution 152 commending the Pentagon Memorial Fund, and he asks that when the House adjourns today, it do so in the honor and memory of the victims of the Pentagon Memorial.

[00:24:13] All those in favor shall please rise. The resolution is agreed to.

[00:24:35] Delegate from Warren County, Delegate Oates. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for a motion. The delegate has the floor. I move to take out of order H.R. 125 from today's calendar. Clerk will report a resolution.

[00:24:51] Excuse me, House Resolution 125, commending Alice Barlow. Delegate from Warren County, Delegate Oaks. Mr. Speaker, I move adoption of the resolution. I request to speak to the motion. Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, get ready to hear a lot about horses.

[00:25:09] I rise today with the distinct honor to recognize an exceptional horsewoman, dedicated, professional, and proud Virginian, Alice Barlow of Warren County. And I would ask her to rise, but she already is. So that's great.

[00:25:25] In the Commonwealth of Virginia, horsemanship is more than a sport. It's a proud part of our heritage, our agricultural economy, and our way of life. From the foothills of the Blue Ridge Mountains to the farms and show rings across the Shendo Valley, equestrian excellence is woven into the very fabric of our culture.

[00:25:43] A graduate of Randolph-Macon Academy, class of 2009, Ms. Barlow, has paired academic excellence with extraordinary talent in the equine industry. She earned not one, but two Bachelor of Science degrees in 2013 from University of Finley, one in equine business management, one in equine studies with a Western emphasis, and then went on to complete her Master's of Education in 2014.

[00:26:10] But what happened in November of 2025 is why she's here today. Alice distinguished herself nationally in the highly competitive Gypsy Vanner National Championship in Belton, Texas, showing her four-year-old mare a summer song, affectionately known as Sunny. She competed in 16 classes, placing in 15 of those. Among those impressive finishes, she also earned three national grand championships and four reserve national

[00:26:43] championships. Trust me, that's a big deal. Her championships were earned across multiple disciplines western english trail halter and dressage demonstrating not only the versatility of her horse but also the depth of alice's skill as a trainer and rider reflecting both technical precision and a deep understanding of horsemanship a successful businesswoman as well owning and operating team barlow in middletown virginia where one can board train and compete in all

[00:27:16] equine disciplines. Mr. Speaker, Alice Barlow represents the very best of Virginia. Discipline, perseverance, excellence, and a commitment to lifting others. Her success brings pride to our commonwealth and our region, showcasing the strength of Virginia's equestrian tradition on the national stage. I would welcome the members to give Alice Barlow a warm house welcome.

[00:27:44] The delegate from Warren County, Delegate Oates, moves that we pass House Resolution No. 125, commending Alice Barlow.

[00:28:02] All those in favor say aye. All those opposed, no. The resolution is agreed to. Congratulations. The delegate from Richmond City, Delegate Cousins. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a motion and an introduction.

[00:28:20] The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House take up out of order H.J. 154 on page 12 of today's calendar. Clerk, I move adoption of the resolution, and I request to speak to that motion.

[00:28:43] The delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, H.J. 154 recognizes the contributions and achievements of the Greater Richmond Chapter of the Afro-American Historical and Genealogical Society. On the House floor today, we are joined by former Secretary of Administration and Delegate Viola Baskerville, along with several members of this society, and I would ask that they please rise to be recognized.

[00:29:10] The society recently celebrated its 15th anniversary and is one of 36 chapters across the nation dedicated to preserving African-ancestored family history, genealogy, and cultural diversity. The Greater Richmond Chapter was named the 2022 Chapter of the Year for its outstanding programs in support of the organization's mission.

[00:29:33] The Society has established a reputation for scholarly research and innovative programming with members who are sought-after presenters and members in lineage societies and other widely recognized genealogical societies. The Society highlights the importance of knowing and understanding our history and honoring those who came before us.

[00:29:53] Mr. Speaker, as we celebrate Black History Month, I am immensely grateful for trailblazers like former Secretary and Delegate Baskerville, who paved the way for me and so many others to serve and lead today. I want to thank the society for their continued work and ask the members to join me in giving them a warm House welcome.

[00:30:14] Delegate from Richmond, Delegate Cousins, move that we adopt House Joint Resolution 154, committing the Great in Richmond, Virginia, Chapter of the Afro-American Historical and Genealogical Society, Incorporated.

[00:30:34] All those in favor say aye. All those opposed no. The resolution is agreed to. Congratulations. The Delegate from Bonatide, Delegate Austin.

[00:30:49] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for an introduction. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Joining us in the gallery today are cadets and officers from Virginia Military Institute. And I would ask that you rise, please. Founded in 1839, VMI is the oldest state-supported military college in the country.

[00:31:06] These cadets are part of a group of upperclassmen in Richmond today meeting with their legislators legislators to thank them for their support of higher education and the institution institute this evening the cadets will join alum faculty and staff at vmi at the library of virginia for the institute's annual legislative reception from 6 to 8 p.m please come by and visit with them mr speaker i would hope it'd be a pleasure to body and give the vmi cadets

[00:31:33] a warm house welcome welcome welcome to the capital today delegate from warren county delegate oaks thank you mr speaker i'm sorry but they weren't in here when I did the last introduction. Mr. Speaker, I rise for another introduction. The delegate has the floor. It is my pleasure to introduce students from every region of Virginia sponsored by the STEM Education Advisory Board, and I would ask that they please

[00:32:13] stand. Mr. Speaker, I want to recognize the Governor's STEM Academies and the Data Science and Computing Lab Schools of Frederick County, and the Data Science and Computing Lab School provides high school students with a unique opportunity to earn free college credit and industry-recognized credentials while exploring cutting-edge fields in the computing and data science area. The Virginia STEM Education Advisory Board advises the governor and members of the Cabinet on strategies to align STEM education efforts across the Commonwealth

[00:32:52] and reports on the challenges, goals, and successes of STEM education in Virginia. In In the coming weeks, the Virginia Department of Education will be announcing the regional STEM hubs to start the state STEM ecosystem. Through these STEM programs, they are gaining hands-on experience and exploring career pathways that will strengthen Virginia's workforce and future economy.

[00:33:17] The state STEM ecosystem hopes to expand opportunities such as these to all students in the Commonwealth of Virginia. The students you see here today represent high schools from across the Commonwealth, including all the data science and computing schools.

[00:33:33] They are using technology, you may have seen them up on the seventh floor today, to solve real-world problems. I would ask the House would give these young students and their teachers a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:33:58] Delegate from Henrico, Delegate McQuinn. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker and the members of the House, in the House Gallery today, we have students and teachers from Krista Ray Richmond High School.

[00:34:21] If they're here, I'm going to ask that they would please stand. Krista Ray Richmond is a Catholic college preparatory high school that serves students from families of limited economic means, combining rigorous academics with a unique corporate work study program that gives students valuable professional experience while helping to fund their education.

[00:34:43] Part of the National Crystal Ray Network of Schools, Crystal Ray Richmond opened in 2019 and has served students from across the region, including Richmond, Henrico, Chesterfield, Hanover,

Powhatan, Petersburg, Chester, and Hopewell.

[00:34:59] The school's mission is to form young men and women of faith, purpose, and service, preparing them not only for success in college, but also for a meaningful career and community leadership. Through their classroom learning and the real-world placement with local business partners, these students are gaining skills, confidence, and a vision to how they will continue the future of our Commonwealth.

[00:35:25] Every student in the class of 2026 has earned acceptance to four-year colleges. Their remarkable success includes offers from the renowned Virginia institutions, such as the University of Virginia, Virginia Tech, the College of William & Mary, James Madison University, Longwood University, and Hollins University.

[00:35:46] So I ask if you would please join with me at this time and welcome this remarkable group of young people and young leaders to the gallery, to the Commonwealth. Well, welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:36:11] Welcome. The delegate from Lynchburg, Delegate Walker. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, we have a lot of wonderful folks that visit us here in this Capitol. And today, I was really encouraged when I had some visitors from my own hometown, the city of Lynchburg.

[00:36:32] And they were wearing white coats. I said, Lord, is it my time? But these are the hope of our future. Since there's such a shortage of medical students, I'd like to introduce you to the Liberty University School of Osteopathic Medicine.

[00:36:49] If these wonderful folks would stand up, you can't miss them because they have their white coats on today. But these are students that come to speak to us regarding medical society issues. They're advocates here for issues related to their practice of medicine.

[00:37:05] Since opening the doors to the first class of students, doctors, in 2014, LUCOM, as it's known, is the second college of its kind in the Commonwealth and the 13th in the United States. LUCOM's education combines state-of-the-art facilities with diverse research opportunities.

[00:37:26] These students learn alongside experienced faculty who are grounded in their Christian faith and while they seek to fulfill their passion for serving others. By being here today and through these studies, these students are making their mark well before they graduate. We hope to see them stay in the Commonwealth, Virginia, for a long, long time.

[00:37:46] Would you give these great folks from Lynchburg a warm house welcome? Thank you. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:38:03] Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Tran. Thank you so much, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker and members of the House joining us in the gallery today are representatives and supporters of CRI, and I ask them to rise.

[00:38:20] CRI, which stands for Choice, Respect, and Independence, is a Northern Virginia-based nonprofit that has been serving our communities for nearly 50 years. It provides personalized, professional support to adults with developmental disabilities, autism, significant mental health needs, and complex behavioral challenges, as well as to youth who've aged out of foster care.

[00:38:43] CRI is committed to serving individuals within the communities where they live, offering high-quality residences for adults and youth, day programs, home-based clinical and practical supports, case management, and transitional support, by helping some of our most vulnerable neighbors live with dignity, stability, and independence.

[00:39:03] I ask that you join me in giving CRI a warm house welcome. Thank you. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Rockingham, Delegate Runyon.

[00:39:19] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Doug has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, the Air Conditioning, Heating, and Refrigeration Institute represents over 330 manufacturers of heating, ventilation, air conditioning, commercial refrigeration, and water heating equipment.

[00:39:43] Standing in the gallery today are representatives from the major manufacturers here in the Commonwealth. Daikin, who is based in Verona, Virginia, my district. Carrier, Trane Technologies, Rheem, and A.O. Smith.

[00:40:00] AHRI is a recognized advocate of the heating, ventilation, air conditioning, and refrigeration industry and certifies the performance of many of the products these manufacturers produce. In North America, the annual economic activity resulting from the HVACR industry is more than $211 billion.

[00:40:20] In the United States alone, member companies, along with distribution contractors and technicians, employ more than 700,000 folks. I ask my colleagues to please give these manufacturing industry experts a warm house welcome. Welcome, welcome to the Capitol Day.

[00:40:47] The delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Sullivan. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise with a motion. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I move that when the House adjourned today, it do so in the honor and memory of Claudia Hantman Arco. And I'd like to speak to that motion, Mr. Speaker.

[00:41:03] The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Members of the body, just a few days ago, we passed House Joint Resolution 128. HDR 128 is special to many of us in this body as it celebrates the life of Claudia Arco. We are honored to have Claudia's husband and children joining us in the gallery, and I hope they'll join us in helping to celebrate her life, and please stand.

[00:41:25] Mr. Speaker, Claudia Arco served Fairfax County for over 20 years, most recently as its legislative director, a role to which she brought her deep policy expertise, sharp intellect, tenacious work ethic, and commitment to public service.

[00:41:47] Claudia was universally recognized as a leader by her peers in the community of local government advocates. She was known for her skill in building alliances and partnerships within Northern Virginia and across the Commonwealth, and for joining forces to advocate on issues that unite large and small jurisdictions alike.

[00:42:06] Claudia had a talent for friendship and a keen sense of humor that enabled her to cultivate tight bonds with the Fairfax County Board of Supervisors, members of the Fairfax County delegation to the General Assembly, and her colleagues and other local government advocates, establishing a sense of camaraderie and mission.

[00:42:26] Claudia had a long list of professional achievements, Mr. Speaker, but she was first and foremost a devoted wife, mother, and friend. She served as president of her local parent-teacher

association, organized sporting teams, and served as a team mom, championing her children in all of their endeavors.

[00:42:46] Claudia's many contributions throughout her life of public service and her work to improve the partnership between the Commonwealth and county governments will continue to benefit residents of Fairfax County and Virginia for years to come, Mr. Speaker. So, Mr. Speaker, Claudia will be fondly remembered and dearly missed by many of us who work in and around the General Assembly.

[00:43:08] And I move today that when the House adjourned, it do so in the honor and memory of Claudia Hantman Arco. Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Sullivan moves that when the House adjourned today, it do so in the honor and memory of Claudia Hantman Arco.

[00:43:24] As many as favor the motion will please rise. The motion is agreed to. The delegate from Spotsylvania, Delegate Scott.

[00:43:49] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I'll rise for an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Today, we have members of the Virginia Propane Gas Association who are holding their annual legislative luncheon in the Capitol Square, and I hope you all had a chance to participate. If those members of the association please rise. The leader of that organization, Mr. Speaker, for 2025 and 2026 is Jameson Walker, who runs Blossom & Gas, Virginia, and is a resident of my district.

[00:44:13] I know that the men and women of the Propane Association work day and night throughout this past winter to keep their customers warm during those cold snaps and that bad weather that we had. I hope the colleagues in this House will extend a warm House welcome to Jameson Walker of Blossom and Gas.

[00:44:33] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. And I need to get my propane tanks changed. Delegate from here in RICO, Delegate LeVere Bowling. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a motion.

[00:44:49] Delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House take up out of order, H.J.R. 153, on page 12 of today's calendar. Clerk will report a resolution. House Joint Resolution 153, celebrating the life of Sincere B. Allah.

[00:45:08] Delegate from Enrico, Delegate Cousins. I mean, I'm sorry, Delegate LaVere Bowley. Mr. Speaker, I move adoption of the resolution and request to speak to that motion. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I rise today to honor the life of my beloved constituent, Sincere be Allah.

[00:45:25] A respected advocate, a devoted father, and a trusted voice for justice in the Commonwealth. And today in the gallery, his family and friends are with us, and if they're able, I ask that they please stand. Sincere was known to many as a gentle giant, a man of humility, compassion, and quiet strength.

[00:45:49] Having endured more than two decades of incarceration, he came home determined, not just to rebuild his own life, but to reach back and pull others forward. And he did exactly that. As Virginia State Organizer for Reform Alliance, Sincere worked across political and ideological lines to advance probation reform, sentencing reform, and second-look legislation.

[00:46:15] He shared his lived experience to help inform thoughtful, bipartisan policymaking. Members of this body came to know him not just as an advocate, but as a man of integrity, someone who believed deeply in redemption, accountability, and second chances.

[00:46:32] But beyond his public work, Sincere showed up for people. He mentored youth, supported fellow returning citizens, and stood ten toes down for those he loved. He reminded people that they were more than their past, that growth is possible, and that every life has value.

[00:46:54] His passing, following a mental health crisis, is a painful reminder that re-entry does not end at the prison gate. The weight people carry after incarceration is real. The trauma is real. And our commitment to second chances must include meaningful access to mental health care and support.

[00:47:15] Sincere mattered. His life mattered. His work mattered. His voice mattered. We honor him by continuing the work he believed in so fiercely, building a more just, more humane commonwealth, and checking in on our people along the way.

[00:47:33] May he rest in power, and may his light continue to guide us forward. And with that, Mr. Speaker, I'd like to yield time to the Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Shin. Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Shin. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I'm going to ask for a little bit of patience as I try to get through this, because I'm feeling pretty emotional today.

[00:47:51] Because last Friday, the advocacy community lost a champion and I lost a friend. I met Sincere in 2022, just a few months after he was granted a pardon by then-Governor Northam. Senator Boisco was hosting him in Herndon, and we became fast friends over pizza and beer. After that, regularly scheduled family dinners were a regular and routine part of my schedule here in Richmond during session and in the off-season, too.

[00:48:14] I came to know Sincere as exactly how the delegate from Henrico described him, as a gentle giant. He was a sweet spirit, he was kind, and he was generous to his core. I saw him just last week coming out of HHS, and he gave me a big hug and had a huge grin on his face like he always did and checked in on me.

[00:48:33] Sincere was incarcerated at 18 and spent more than two decades behind bars, but inside a system designed to punish you rather than rehabilitate you. Sincere's life was extraordinary, and it was an extraordinary testament to resilience and redemption. While incarcerated, he kept working to better himself, learning new trades, taking courses through UVA's Darden School, and even becoming a peer recovery specialist, dedicating his time to helping his fellow incarcerated brothers through mental health and substance use disorders.

[00:49:02] He even designed his own personal growth curriculum for a therapeutic community that eventually made its way to 11 different DOC facilities. Just weeks after receiving his pardon, Sincere got straight to work, reentering the community as an organizer for Reform Alliance, showing up here in the General Assembly to advocate for legislation like Second Look and becoming a trusted and thoughtful voice for criminal justice reform.

[00:49:26] His character was always on full display each step of the way as a man who cared deeply, who was committed to fixing an unjust system, and who embodied everything we mean when we talk about redemption. Mr. Speaker, my heart is broken because I grieve the loss of a friend I admired and adored.

[00:49:43] But I've experienced grief before, and this grief hits a little different. And I think that extra layer of complexity is because of the hat I wear as a legislator. Because I'm struggling to separate my grief in losing a friend from my role in upholding a system that failed him.

[00:50:01] What made Sincere remarkable was that he beat the odds. He was remarkable not because the system worked, but in spite of the system. He was the exception and not the norm, and even so, even for someone as extraordinary as Sincere, the wounds from a system cut deep and they don't always heal.

[00:50:17] Mr. Speaker, a broken system produces broken people, and I often feel like we are not doing enough to fix that. I am certain that we do not adequately equip people leaving incarceration with the skills to cope with their emotions, to rebuild relationships, or to navigate the challenges that life throws their way.

[00:50:33] Sincere's death is a painful reminder that exceptionalism is not a substitute for a justice system that could actually work. I mourn my friend and I mourn his potential. And Mr. Speaker, I can't help but feel a little bit resentful at a system that leaves people so lost that Sincere felt he had no other way forward.

[00:50:51] Feelings are complicated though, Mr. Speaker, because today I wanted to also celebrate his life. I'm really proud of Sincere. I'm proud to have known him. And I'm proud of his legacy and all that he represented, especially the wonderful possibility of redemption and the beauty of human resilience. A lot of us in this body, including Delegate Siebold and Delegate Cousins, we were lucky to call Sincere our friend, and together we grieve his death, but we also commit to carrying his memory in our hearts and in our work in the days ahead.

[00:51:19] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Henrico, DeGalavere Bowling, moves the adoption of House Joint Resolution 153, and she moves that when the House adjourned the day, it do so in the honor and memory of sincere be Allah, as many favor the motion shall rise.

[00:51:48] The motion is agreed to.

[00:51:58] Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate McGuire. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for an introduction. The delegate has the floor.

[00:52:15] Mr. Speaker, on the House floor with us today is my predecessor from the 17th District, former Delegate and current Secretary of Finance, Mark Sickles. I hope we can give him a warm welcome back to this floor. He's only been gone five minutes. Y'all doing all of that?

[00:52:42] Welcome back and happy belated birthday. Yesterday was his birthday as well. The Delegate from Enrico, Delegate Willett. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purposes of an introduction. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, joining us today in the gallery are second grade students from St. Bridget's School here in Richmond. I ask if they please rise. Mr. Speaker, this excellent group of students that join us today, as I mentioned, from St. Bridget's, they're spending their day at the Capitol, accompanied by their teachers and assistant principal. It'll be the pleasure of this body to give them a warm house welcome.

[00:53:23] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol. You guys are the most well-behaved second graders I've ever seen. Can you come down and help these second graders?

[00:53:41] Welcome to the Capitol today. The delegate from Fredericksburg, Delegate Cole. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for yet again another introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. In the gallery joining us today, we have members from the reformed 23rd Infantry Regiment, United States Colored Troops.

[00:53:58] And I would ask if they would please stand if they're able. The original 23rd Infantry Regiment, USCT, was organized at Camp Casey in Arlington, and on May 15, 1864, near Chancellorsville, became the first black regiment to engage in directed combat against General Robert E. Lee's Army of Northern Virginia, driving back Confederate cavalry and proving their valor under fire.

[00:54:21] The regiment went on to serve in Petersburg, at the crater, and through Appomattox. Today, the regiment lives again, Mr. Speaker. The reformed regiment serves to preserve that history and honors the legacy of those who fought for freedom, democracy, and liberation.

[00:54:37] I would ask the members of the House, along with Delegate Scott, Delegate Cole, Delegate Carroll, and Delegate Franklin, and giving them a warm House welcome.

[00:54:58] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Y'all look amazing. Thank you. Delegate from Newport News, Delegate Price. Mr. Speaker, I rise for an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. We have students from the 7th grade civics class at Hampton Roads Academy in Newport News with their teachers and staff, and I ask that they please stand in the gallery.

[00:55:21] And hello to those in House Room 3 as well. HRA serves as pre-K through 12th grade and is an independent school offering an inclusive community of service and compassion that prepares students to excel intellectually, artistically, physically, and morally in higher education and in life.

[00:55:41] These students have spent months studying civics, including the three branches of state-level government. They have scrutinized some of our legislation, advocated through emails and phone calls, and exercised their civic power that is the basis of our democracy.

[00:55:57] We wish them well in their studies, and I hope it will be the pleasure of the body to give them a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:56:12] Delegate from Norfolk, Delegate Anthony. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. It is my honor to introduce the young women of Bina High School for Jewish Girls located in my district. And if they are in the gallery, I ask them to stand and remain standing.

[00:56:32] Today, Mr. Speaker, these bright and engaged students are visiting the Capitol as part of their studies in the United States government, learning not only how democracy works, but actively participating in it. And they are witnessing firsthand the legislative process, civic dialogue, and the responsibility that comes with leadership and public service.

[00:56:52] And we are grateful for their commitment to learning, their curiosity about government, and their dedication to being informed and engaged citizens. So please join me, Mr. Speaker, and members of the House in welcoming the students and educators of Beener High School and give them a warm house welcome.

[00:57:09] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. The Delegate from Chesterfield, Delegate Gartner. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:57:25] Mr. Speaker, I rise for a motion. The delegate has the floor. I move that H.R. 129 on page 12 be passed by until February 26th. Delegate from Chesterfield moves that House Resolution 129 found on page 12 go by until February 26th.

[00:57:43] Without objection, H.R. 129 goes by until February 26th. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Fauquier, Delegate McAuliffe. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purposes of an introduction. Delegate has the floor. I rise today to recognize an outstanding group of young leaders visiting us from Northern Virginia as part of the Electric Cooperative Youth Tour Program, and I ask them to please stand.

[00:58:09] These students represent NOVEC and were selected for their leadership, academic achievement, and commitment to their communities, and as part of the Youth Tour, they will join fellow student leaders residing in different electric cooperative territories from across the country for a visit to Washington. But before they did that, we wanted to make sure they visited here to understand how things really get done.

[00:58:29] So, please give them a warm House welcome.

[00:58:42] Welcome, welcome to the Capitol. Pursuant to House Rule 30, the journal shall reflect that the following members are away on pressing personal business, so don't grant a leave from today's session. Delegate Clark, Knight, Phillips, and Ware. Clerk will announce the next order of business. Ms. Speaker, the second and third portion of the morning hour, given today's calendar, neither are applicable.

[00:59:02] Clerk will announce the next order. And the fourth and final portion of the morning hour, reserved for member requests for points of personal privilege. The Speaker kindly asks that you use your request to speak button to get into the queue. Delegate from Prince William, Delegate Guzman. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor.

[00:59:18] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise today to reflect on a moment that reached millions of Americans last weekend. Not because it was political, but because it was profoundly human. At the Super Bowl halftime show, Bad Bunny, performing the language he grew up speaking, not to make a statement, not to exclude anyone, but simply to be himself.

[00:59:45] And in doing so, he reminded us of something very old and very American. That expression, culture, and identity are not threats. They are strengths. For generations, people in this country have attended operas, ballets, concerts, and performances in languages they did not speak.

[01:00:09] And yet, they understood the emotion, the joy, the struggle, the pride. because music, like art itself, does not require translation to be felt. What mattered about that moment wasn't the language.

[01:00:26] It was the story it told. The story about belonging, the story about visibility, the story about a country shape not owned not by one voice, but by many. I think about a child growing up hearing one language at home and another at the school, just like my children did.

[01:00:48] About learning, sometimes too early, that who you are might not always feel welcome in public spaces. It is tough, Mr. Speaker. I remember my oldest child blaming her last name when things did not go well in school.

[01:01:07] She's 34 now. And about what this performance means to me and many people who look like me. Years later, to see someone stand confidently on that world's biggest stage and say without apology, this is who I am.

[01:01:27] That matters, Mr. Speaker, because representation is not about exclusion, it's about recognition. It tells people watching, especially young people, that their voices count, that their stories

belong, that they do not have to choose between their culture and their country.

[01:01:46] This is not a new story in America. It is the American story. A nation shaped by different languages, traditions, and journeys, each one adding to the whole. When we make room for that, we don't lose anything. We gain understanding. We gain connection. We gain strength.

[01:02:07] Mr. Speaker, moments like these remind us that progress doesn't always arrive through policy or debate. Sometimes it arrives through art, through empathy, through listening. And if we are willing to listen to stories that do not mirror our own, we may find that we understand one another a little better.

[01:02:31] Because together, we are America. Because when one culture is seen, we all move forward, Mr. Speaker. Thank you. The Delegate from Rockingham, Delegate Wilt.

[01:02:54] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise from the point of a personal privilege. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. And ladies and gentlemen of the House, we're past halfway through the session. I thought it was important to stand up, just take a few moments to look at what we did and what we didn't do.

[01:03:16] Mr. Speaker, during the last election cycle, energy liability and affordability were widely acknowledged as bipartisan concerns. Members of leadership in the majority even signaled that changes to our energy policy, including the Virginia Clean Economy Act, were likely necessary.

[01:03:37] There were promises of affordability and reliability. Well, now we're past the election and past crossover, and no meaningful reform has been enacted that will significantly lower electric bills or address growing reliability concerns.

[01:03:54] Yes, we passed a few measures that kind of work around the edges, and some of that I supported. But we should not ignore the larger reality. We are on a collision course when it comes to electric affordability and reliability.

[01:04:11] Commissioners from PJM Interconnection recently have continually been warning us that the grid is in serious danger of not having enough generation to meet demand. As the top importer in the PJM territory, we have a responsibility to do our part to address this looming crisis.

[01:04:31] This session, we advanced additional battery storage requirement, including long-duration storage technology. But that's just not grid scale, and it's certainly not affordable. Mr. Speaker, I'm not anti-battery, but batteries have limits.

[01:04:48] During peak winter demand, when dispatchable sources are already running at full capacity, and wind and solar output is extremely low or non-existent, there's nothing left to store. We cannot substitute storage for generation.

[01:05:04] Both sides say they support an all-the-above strategy. And I'm glad to see the other side finally acknowledge nuclear as part of that conversation. But, Mr. Speaker, natural gas must remain part of the mix also for the foreseeable future. A little fact that we need to remember, we've seen well over 40 percent reductions in Virginia's carbon emissions the last 15 years or so, precisely because of increased natural gas generation.

[01:05:34] Yet these concerns remain. Mr. Speaker, this year, that's why I introduced legislation to pause the escalating mandates of the Virginia Clean Economy Act. Not repeal them, but to pause them, to give our utilities time to plan and develop our grid in a thoughtful and cost-conscious way.

[01:05:51] Other members offered proposals to create relief valves in consumer, if consumer costs spikes or reliability is threatened, none of those bills received a hearing. Looking at costs alone, the record this session is troubling.

[01:06:08] We've chosen to rejoin the regional greenhouse gas initiative, amounts to a pass-through tax on ratepayers, expanding battery requirements on our utilities as estimated to cost billions.

[01:06:26] Costs on an expanded weatherization program and percentage of income program will ultimately be borne by existing ratepayers, despite some initial assurances that that falsely indicated otherwise. If we stay on this path, rates will continue to rise and the risk of regular brownouts and blackouts will grow. But I suspect in about 16, 18 months, we'll suddenly start seeing renewed interest in reforming the very policies that are driving these outcomes. Mr. Speaker, the Virginia

[01:06:59] Clean Economy Act ship is taking on water, and instead of patching the holes, we're rearranging the deck chairs. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Fredericksburg, Delegate Cole.

[01:07:19] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. In accordance with our traditions of observing Black History Month, I pose a question to you today, Mr. Speaker. Who's your people? In the black community, this question is often asked not just to know who you are, but to know who you are.

[01:07:39] When I first ran in 2017, I visited areas in my district like Mayfield, Old Forge, black churches like New Sight and Old Sight and Bethlehem and Mount Zion. And the older saints would ask me, who's your people? This question carries generations inside of it, Mr. Speaker.

[01:07:57] It's not small talk. It's not gossip. It's genealogy. It's geography and it's responsibility. When we ask who's your people, we are asking who raised you? Who prayed over you? who endured so that you could stand here today what community formed you and what community are you held accountable to scripture speaks of a great cloud of witnesses those who have gone on before us but yet still surround us today and for black virginians mr speaker that cloud is thick it is sacred and it is unbroken we are shaped by ancestors who names we do know and names we may

[01:08:36] not know we are shaped by hands who picked tobacco in south side virginia by feet that marched here in the streets of Richmond, by students who walked out of segregated schools, by mothers and fathers who built churches, businesses, and civic leagues when the law did not protect them. That great cloud includes Gabriel Prosser, who dared to imagine freedom in Richmond.

[01:09:00] It includes Nat Turner in Southampton County, who believed liberation was worth the ultimate cause. It includes Maggie Lena Walker, who built economic power in Jackson Ward so her community can stand on its own. It included Barbara Johns, a young woman from Prince Edward County who refused to accept an equal education. It included Oliver Hill, who fought segregation in courtrooms across this commonwealth. And still today includes L. Douglas Wilder, who proved that even the highest office in Virginia was not out of reach for young black men and women. It also includes Arthur Ashe, who used excellence and a quiet conviction to challenge

[01:09:38] on a global stage, and Booker T. Washington, born and enslaved in Franklin County, who built institutions that trained generations to lead. Those are not just historical figures, Mr. Speaker. For black Virginians today, they are our people. If you are a black attorney advocating for fairness in our justice

system, Oliver Hill and Don Scott is your people. If you are a black banker, entrepreneur, or small business owner, building generational wealth, Maggie Lena Walker and Stacey Carroll is your people.

[01:10:10] If you are a student advocate demanding dignity in your schools, Barbara Johns and Zayana Bryan of Charlottesville is your people. If you are an athlete using your platform for justice, Arthur Ashe and over there down the hallway, Aaron Rouse, those are your people.

[01:10:25] If you are called to public service in this chamber or beyond Governor Wilder and Yvonne Miller, that's your people. If you are serving your country in our armed forces and putting your life on the line, Dr. Urbane Bass, and Michael Feggans, that's your people.

[01:10:42] If you are organizing neighbors, mentoring youth, or protecting our community, you stand in a long tradition of Virginians who believed our communities were worth defending. That great cloud of witnesses, Mr. Speaker, is not passive. They continue to shape us.

[01:10:57] They challenge us. They watch what we do with the inheritance they left behind. To know who your people are is to know what we owe them. We owe them safe communities. We owe them thriving schools. We owe them economic opportunity. We owe them justice, and we owe them courage.

[01:11:15] And we are doing our good work during this session today to deliver to our ancestors what they left for us to do. Because one day, generations will, yet unborn, look back at us and say, who are your people? And may the answer be the ones who were remembered, the ones who protected us, the ones who built something worthy of their ancestors.

[01:11:37] So, Mr. Speaker, during this Black History Month, may we honor the great cloud of witnesses and continue the heart, the message, who's your people? Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Rockingham, Delegate Runyon.

[01:12:05] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I request to return to the first morning hour for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I'm sorry. I apologize. An announcement, Mr. The delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, as a board member of the Senator Frank M. Ruff, Jr., Center for Rural Virginia, I am pleased to announce the third Rural Caucus meeting for the 2026 General Assembly session will occur this afternoon at 5 p.m.

[01:12:31] We will meet in the ninth-room floor meeting room. Thank you. As today's Rural Caucus meeting, we will hear from the Honorable Jessica Luhmann, Virginia Secretary of Labor, and Tony McDowell, Executive Director of the Opioid Abatement Authority.

[01:12:47] Only one more Rural Caucus meeting left after this one. We hope to see you there. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Scott County, Delegate Kilgore. Mr. Speaker, I request a return to the first morning hour for an introduction. Delican has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[01:13:02] On January 26th, we passed House Resolution 20 honoring Eddie Thomas, and Eddie's in the gallery field stand. Eddie comes all the way from Lee County today to join us where he faithfully served at what was once Lee Regional Medical Center.

[01:13:18] Today, Lee County Community Hospital since 1975, Mr. Speaker. It was my honor to sponsor House Resolution 20 that passed earlier this session commending Eddie for his 50 years of service to his community. Through those five decades, he remained through mergers, challenges, and even the hospital's closure.

[01:13:38] He safeguarded the facility during the difficult chapter and played a vital role in its reopening in 2021. So please join me in celebrating Eddie's remarkable dedication and congratulating him on his retirement by welcoming him to the House floor today.

[01:13:54] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Welcome and congratulations. The clerk will call the calendar. Calendar for today, Thursday, February 19, 2026.

[01:14:11] There is no business before the body. Per House Rule 51, the House has returned to the morning hour. Does the clerk have any additional announcements or communications? Just simply the meeting announcements, which are as follows. The Committee on General Laws is meeting a half hour after adjournment today in House Committee Room B.

[01:14:28] So it'll be approximately 1.30-ish over on the second floor, House Committee Room B. And then once a full committee is finished, then it's Professions, Occupation, Administrative Process, Subcommittee is meeting. And then once they are finished, the Housing and Consumer Protection Subcommittee meeting. So General Laws and two of its subs. Similarly, but down in the House Committee Room A in the lower level, the Committee on Labor and Commerce will be meeting.

[01:14:52] They will meet a half hour after adjournment, and then once the full committee is finished, then it's subcommittee number two will be meeting again in the lower level A. No other legislative meetings today. They're canceled, but you can see those if you're so inclined.

[01:15:09] The Career and Technical Education Caucus is to meet at 4 o'clock in House Subcommittee Room 10 up on the 10th floor. And as just was announced, the Rural Caucus will be meeting at 5 o'clock in the House Subcommittee Room 9 on the 9th floor.

[01:15:26] Looking ahead to tomorrow, County, Cities, and Towns Subcommittee No. 1 will be meeting at 7.30 in the House Committee Room B on the 2nd floor. Once they are finished, then subcommittee number 3 will be meeting, and then at 9 a.m., the full committee on county, cities, and towns.

[01:15:45] So two of its subs, one and three, and then the full committee, all that's in House Committee Room B. Committee on Public Safety is going to be meeting at 8 o'clock tomorrow down in the lower level, House Committee Room A. And then at 9 o'clock, the Committee for Privileges and Elections will be meeting, the House Committee, and House Committee Room C.

[01:16:07] And then at 9.30, jointly, the House and Senate committees for privileges and elections will be meeting in House Committee Room C. So P&E at 9, and then a joint meeting of the two committees, House Room C on the second floor.

[01:16:25] And then finally, going in a little bit earlier tomorrow, so the Democratic caucus will be meeting at 10.15, 10.30 tomorrow. We'll update that in House Room 1, Republican caucus at 10.30. Both costs will be meeting at 10.30, Democrats in House Room 1, Republicans in House Room 2. We will update the schedule, and that is all the announcements I have at this time.

[01:16:44] Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Mr. Speaker, I move that when the House adjourns today, adjourn to reconvene tomorrow at 11 a.m. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring moves when the House adjourns today, adjourn to reconvene tomorrow at 11 a.m. As many in favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to the Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring.

[01:17:01] Mr. Speaker, I move that the House do now adjourn. Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring moves that the House do now adjourn. As many in favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The House stands adjourned until tomorrow at 11 a.m.

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